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(70) POVERTY AND JUSTICE IN AFRICAN THEOLOGICAL EDUCATION

Rogate Mshana

Introduction

Addressing issues of poverty and justice in the context of theological education in Africa is already a delayed undertaking, particularly because poverty and injustice are so prevalent on the continent. Poverty has been a perennial problem in Africa, and wealth is created only to benefit the rich within the continent and those outside of it. We read repeatedly of people in the rural areas in Africa who lose their lands to mining companies without compensation (now termed “land grabbing”) and the almost absent investment in production within the continent. At the same time we read of how subsidized agricultural products from Europe and the US are dumped on African markets through forced trade liberalization policies. We read of how multinational corporations pay low wages to miners and reap huge profits and of commodity prices that do not cover production costs of peasants – the list is long. It has been mentioned over and over again that Africa is poor but rich in resources. Books have been written and cutting edge research has indicated that natural resources in Africa have turned out to be a curse rather than a blessing to the continent.

Over a period of 30 years (i.e.1981 to 2008), the region saw a modest 3 percentage drop in the poverty headcount to 48 percent. However, the absolute number of impoverished Africans increased from 205 million to 386 million in the same time. Moreover, Africa continues to be characterised by massive socio-economic inequalities. The median Gini coefficient (a common measure of inequality) stands at 0.42, with Botswana, South Africa, Namibia, Comoros and Seychelles registering the highest rates of inequality of over 0.6.¹

In order to understand the current challenges on poverty eradication it is essential to relate it to how wealth is created. Poverty and wealth are two sides of the same coin. In the current era of globalization (as much as in the previous period of colonisation) wealth creation and accumulation have often taken place at the expense of vulnerable people and ecology, thereby generating economic, social and ecological injustice. In the context of Africa, unfavourable trade agreements and dependence on external debt destroyed farmers’ livelihoods and small-scale businesses, as well as strangled public resources for health and education. According to Leonce Ndikumana the following holds true: *“On a net basis, African countries often have paid annually to the rest of the world more than they have received from external borrowing.”*²

Overall, the picture that has emerged is that poverty in Africa is caused not by a lazy populace but by greed and injustice as expressed in Proverbs 13:23: *“The fields of the poor may yield much food, but it is swept away through injustice.”* To what extent has theological education embraced economic, social and ecological justice in its curriculum and offered a critical analysis of the root causes of poverty? This is the focal question of this essay. Theological education in Africa must attend to human avarice and greed at individual, structural and cultural levels as this is at the heart of exploitation of human beings and of the Earth – it is at the heart of injustice.

Theological education does have a role to play in creating alternative value systems and economic and ecological justice ought to be embraced in its curriculum. Therefore, this article will make a case for the

¹ The Gini coefficient is a number between 0 and 1, where 0 corresponds with perfect equality (where everyone has the same income) and 1 corresponds with perfect inequality (where one person has all the income). Data on inequality in Africa are from <http://www.wolframalpha.com/input/?i=Gini+index+of+African+countries>.

² See: <http://triplecrisis.com/africa-can-win-the-fight-against-poverty-if-it-can-keep-its-resources-onshore/2012>

urgency for theological students to be exposed in their studies to a critical analysis of the root causes of poverty in Africa and become aware of available alternatives.

The Issues to be Addressed

In order to understand the current challenges to poverty eradication it is essential to relate this to how wealth is created. Poverty and wealth are two sides of the same coin. To add to that is the concern for ecology. It is important to underline that poverty, wealth and ecology cannot be separated from one another when it comes to an accurate analysis of the realities in Africa. It is now obvious that creating wealth at the expense of people in poverty and of the Earth creates what we term as economic, social and ecological injustice. Theological education needs to define, and analyse these issues for Africa, in an integrated way.

Any curriculum on theological education has to begin with gaining clarity of the terms *“economic justice”* and *“ecological justice”*. This will lead to exploring the understanding of a *“transformative theology”* as this is the need of the hour. A relevant theological education agenda today has to address the challenges of the negative impact of neo-liberal economic globalization on everyone – including even those who have been pushing it on to the world, as we see its consequences on all people and on the Earth. A theological curriculum has to address human avarice and greed as these are the ethical questions lying at the heart of exploitation of some human beings by others, and of the Earth itself. This is the core of injustice and demands an alternative moral voice from the Church.³

Justice has too often been defined as “giving to each what is due” or of “treating equal cases equally”. However, in the Christian understanding, justice transcends such concepts which are based on the distributive paradigm of liberal philosophies on life and on justice. Justice has to embrace a set of basic human values. Justice is one of the four “cardinal virtues” of moral philosophy, along with courage and temperance (self-control).

St. Paul in his letter to the Corinthians speaks of “faith, hope and charity” as the three greatest virtues. Virtues or “good habits” help individuals to develop their human potentials fully, thus enabling them to serve their own self-interests as well as to work in harmony with others for the common good. In many communities of the South, justice is defined by how humans relate to each other, taken together with their relationships with the Earth. Where relationships between human beings and between humans and the Earth are broken, there is no justice. It also underscores that the way to restore justice is to promote mutual dignity among members of a community. In a context of so much injustice between peoples, between nations and between humanity and the Earth the achievement of forgiveness and reconciliation become key theological principles, in the search for justice.

In the context of Africa, Insights could be drawn from the concept of Ubuntu, “I am because we are”. To what extent has theological education enhanced and deepened the theological understanding of Ubuntu as the African contribution to the discourse on justice and dignity? Ubuntu is about human relationships lived in community, and of harmony with the whole of creation. It finds its parallel in the Asian concept of Sangsaeng, which is about a “sharing community and economy that allows all to flourish together”. From the Biblical perspective, we understand that God created human beings as part of a larger web of life and affirmed the goodness of the whole creation (Genesis 1). *“The whole community of living organisms that grows and flourishes is an expression of God’s will and works together to bring life from and give life to the land, to connect one generation to the next, and to sustain the abundance and diversity of God’s*

³ See Rogate Mshana, ‘Economic and Ecological Justice: Challenging Mission in the 21st Century in the work of the Council for World Mission and the Ecumenical family in Desmond van der Water (ed), *Postcolonial Mission: Power and Partnership in World Christianity* (Upland California: Sopher Press), 180-187

household (Oikos). Economy in God's household emerges from God's gracious offering of abundant life"⁴. Theological education in Africa needs to take up this comprehensive understanding of economy and ecology in order to address adequately the issue of poverty.

Understanding Economic, Social and Ecological Justice

The term "*economic justice*" is often used interchangeably with "*social justice*" – these terms stress different but complementary points. *Economic justice* is about how economic life is organized in terms of production, distribution and consumption of material goods and services. The manner in which these goods and services are produced, distributed and consumed could be done unjustly and hence lead to what is called "*economic injustice*".

Economic justice is defined as that which touches the individual person as well as the social order and encompasses the moral principles which guide us in designing our economic institutions. These institutions determine how each person earns a living, enters into contracts, exchanges goods and services with others and otherwise produces an independent material foundation for his or her economic sustenance. The ultimate purpose of economic justice in such an understanding is to free each person to engage creatively in the unlimited work beyond economics, that of the mind and the spirit. What is missing in such an understanding is the processes for maintaining equity and equality in the sharing of resources with dignity among people and with a deep and sacramental relationship with the Earth. Both justice in communities and justice with the Earth are paramount because without establishing this, individual life and dignity cannot be guaranteed.

"*Social justice*" is about just relationships and encompasses economic justice. Social justice is the virtue which guides us in creating those organized human interactions we call institutions. In turn, social institutions, when justly organized, provide us with access to what is good for the person, both individually and in our associations with others. Social justice also imposes on each of us a personal responsibility to work with others to design and continually perfect our institutions as tools for personal and social development. It involves addressing issues such as inequalities and exclusion at various levels of institutional organization in our societies. Institutions are set up mainly to monitor that all human beings are treated with dignity and that all have the right to enjoy the fruits of their economic achievements. The language of rights is used to emphasize the need to implement "social justice" as "social rights" under the auspices of the United Nations declaration on Economic, Social and Cultural Rights. Social justice as a term is used more often by the churches than by secular institutions because to people of faith, justice goes beyond rights of each individual – it is based on God's justice founded in agape love that embraces the whole community and the Earth.

The terms "*ecological justice*" and "*environmental justice*" surfaced at the end of the last century, when it was recognized, based largely on the wisdom of indigenous communities all over the world that the Earth and its distress needs to be heeded. Indigenous Peoples challenged Christian theologians, ethicists and economists to recognize that the Earth has its own integrity and therefore requires respect. The ecumenical movement has stressed that both the poor and the Earth cry out for justice. Nature can be seen as the new poor, "not the poor that crowds out the human poor, but the 'also' poor; and as such it demands our attention and care."⁵ Leonardo Boff speaks of social ecology as the ways that social and economic systems interact with the natural ecosystem, and "since the human race is part of the environment, social

⁴ "Economy of Life, Justice, and Peace for All: A Call to Action" can be read at the WCC Website: <http://www.oikoumene.org/en/resources/documents/wcc-programmes/public-witness-addressing-power-affirming-peace/poverty-wealth-and-ecology/neoliberal-paradigm/agape-call-for-action-2012.html>.

⁵ Sallie McFague, *Super, Natural Christians: How we should love nature* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1997), 6.

injustice goes hand-in-hand with ecological injustice.”⁶ Larry Rasmussen defines the Earth’s distress as socio-ecological. In other words the rights attributed to the Earth include the rights of **all** of humankind (not just some) to also live and survive.” He underlines that “it is not possible to see ‘humanity’ as some nebulous whole,....but of varied human beings who presently occupy different strata in domestic and world social orders.”⁷ Many environmental and feminist movements have placed the demand for ecological justice at the centre, reminding the world that economy and ecology represent two interrelated and inseparable perspectives on God’s household of life (*oikos*)⁸.

Therefore, the term **ecological justice** is based on two principles: firstly, it is about addressing humanity’s mutilation of the Earth with impunity through production, distribution and consumption – the way humanity manages industries, agriculture, mining, transport etc. Injustice happens when the Earth and its atmosphere are destroyed in the name of generating economic growth. Secondly it addresses the process by which those who are richer and stronger destroy the Earth, further impoverishing the poor, making them even more vulnerable, resulting in social injustice. The WCC policy statement on climate change stresses that climate change is a matter of justice, particularly for those who are and will increasingly be affected – these are the impoverished and vulnerable communities particularly in the global south who are dependent on natural resources for their survival and who do not have the means to adapt to the ecological chaos that climate change provokes.⁹ Restoration of ecological justice is, therefore, an obligation for all human beings. The WCC statement on Climate Change underlines that: “All humanity is made in the image and likeness of God and all nature bears the marks of God. This requires of us to adopt the guiding principle of equity. God’s inheritance is for the communal body, a concept that includes all of nature”¹⁰

Theological education in Africa, therefore needs to encompass a reflection on how God acts to protect and promote justice in creation and in human society. Mission has to regard that where there is **eco-injustice** there is “sin that deeply violates God’s good will, God’s steadfast love for life, for human beings and for the whole creation.”¹¹

Transformative Theological Education

One way for the church to address poverty and injustice in Africa is to ensure that the fundamental issues raised above become an integral part of theological education. At the moment our theology is still traditional in approach and is uncritical of the neo-liberal paradigm that is increasingly creating poverty and ecological destruction on the one hand while on the other ensuring that a few people become extremely rich within each nation and across nations. What is growing on the African continent is a theology of prosperity that has perverted the word of God by portraying people in poverty as being so as a result of their sins. People in poverty are blamed for their poverty rather than exposing to the world the structural injustices that keep people poor. Transformative theological education will be able to raise the critical issues of greed, usury and corruption and restore to the churches and the people the meaning of God’s economy, at the heart of which lies economic, social and ecological justice for all. Transformative

⁶ Leonardo Boff, *Ecology and Liberation: A New Paradigm* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis Books, 2000), 88.

⁷ Larry L. Rasmussen, *Earth Community, Earth Ethics* (Geneva: WCC Publications, 1996), 74.

⁸ Alternative Globalization Addressing Peoples and Earth (AGAPE), Background Document, WCC, JPC, Reprint, Geneva 2006, 40

⁹ Minute on global warming and climate change, WCC Central Committee, Geneva, February 2008.

¹⁰ WCC, *The Earth’s Atmosphere: Responsible Caring and Equitable Sharing For A Global Commons: a Justice Statement regarding Climate Change from the World Council of Churches, for the 6th Session of the Conference of Parties (COP6) to the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change; The Hague, The Netherlands, November 2000* (Unpublished) 2

¹¹ AGAPE:41

theological education should elevate the feminist concept of an economy of care as a way to develop an alternative value system.

Developing an ecological perspective in theological education entails working for and practicing in our own everyday lives, **eco-justice**. This demands costly discipleship in addressing the ongoing plunder of the Earth, which we seem to engage in with impunity. In other words, the churches cannot remain comfortable while being entrenched in a system that continues to destroy the planet through unsustainable production and consumption as well as inequitable economic, social and political systems. Isaiah warns us: “*The Earth lies polluted under its inhabitants; for they have transgressed laws, violated the statutes, broken the everlasting covenant...Therefore a curse devours the Earth, and its inhabitants suffer for their guilt*” (Isaiah 24:5-6a). The intensity and pace at which we are using up the Earth’s “natural resources” reflects an utter lack of care for the Earth’s regeneration and for future generations of living things. Indeed, mission history has reinforced this lack of care – the early mission movements focused on generating life in abundance for all people without consideration of ecological consequences!

Transformative theology as delineated above has to have an impact on and influence for all disciplines of theology, be it biblical studies, theology, Christian ethics, pastoralia, homiletics or spirituality and worship, among others. It is not enough that the issues of poverty and justice are treated as “additional topics” or as optional courses – it should be woven into all a student’s theological education so that they will come out with a heightened awareness of the role the church can play in transforming the lives of the millions living under poverty and injustice; and with a sharp sense of commitment to the Earth. With this in mind four requirements for theological education are listed below.

Theological education’s first requirement in Africa calls for developing an eco-theology that will offer guidance to Christians starting by equipping them with analytical tools on how to change the current systems of greed. The WCC Convocation on Justice, Peace and Integrity of Creation in Seoul in 1990 approved ten theological affirmations and specific covenants for action which provide a description of the inter-relatedness of economic inequality, militarism, ecological destruction, climate change and racial injustice and the theological, ethical and spiritual basis for affirming and sustaining life in its fullness. “Where ever human beings are denied God-created dignity, the rest of creation is denied its dignity also.”¹² The challenge today is to systematize what is already proposed in many churches for a consistent eco-theology and as a corollary to that their eco-mission. Churches in Norway have developed what they term as a “Hustavle” – a set of household rules which are framed and hung on the walls of homes.¹³ One of the rules states: “Rejoice in Beauty: Creation has a wealth of its own. Nothing is mere raw material. The gifts of the Earth must be handled with devotion and gratitude.”

The second requirement of theological education in Africa will be to reclaim the true meaning of stewardship. We have used this theological imperative too as a way to claim dominion – as if the Earth has been given to us to use as we wish. However, **stewardship** ought to point to how to restrain from consumption and production patterns that are unsustainable, by constructing limits to growth. These must become mission priorities. Building just, sustainable and participatory communities could be the way for responsible stewardship – which leads to the development of “a theology for transformation”. We can learn from the project of life-giving agricultural communities that have been promoted by churches in South Korea, who engage in promoting natural and organic agriculture in order to improve the life of the Earth and human beings¹⁴. Stewardship will also mean that the churches and Christians will join hands with

¹² “See Searching for the New Heavens and the New Earth: An Ecumenical Response to The United Nations Conference on Environment and Development”, Baixada Fluminense, Brazil, WCC 1992:9 This was a gathering of 176 people from 52 countries and 70 churches to speak about sustainable Earth following the UNCED Earth Summit.

¹³ See www.kui.no.

¹⁴ See Life Giving Agriculture Global Forum, WCC, WARC, LWF, WSCF, YMCA, YWCA and Frontier in Mission (ECAG) report, Wonju, S. Korea 8-13 April, 2005 Unpublished. There is also A report on the Asian Ecumenical

social movements in challenging agro-industries such as Cargill and Monsanto to abandon death-dealing agriculture based on monoculture and toxic chemical fertilizers and pesticides.¹⁵ Another rule of Hustavle from Norway is: “Remember the context: Your life is woven into the pattern of all life of Earth. All that you have is given to you in trust. You must pass it all on to those who come after you.”

Theological education for transformation leads us to ask a fundamental theological question: Can having more and more especially for the already rich, without any limits, bring real happiness? For this we need to develop not just poverty lines as we tend to focus on this, but we also need greed lines and wealth lines as a guidance for the churches and for individual Christians.¹⁶ Another Hustavle rule states: “Struggle for justice: Mother Earth has enough to meet the needs of all but not to satisfy their greed. The gap between the poor and rich is contempt for human dignity.”

The third requirement for theological education in Africa is to instil in the churches and among Christians the imperative to live an exemplary life. The example of Christ and the Scriptures can inspire us to transform the ways in which we live with each other and with the Earth. But we can also draw lessons from other spiritualities such as those practiced by other faiths and by Indigenous Peoples. For instance, the cosmo-vision of Indigenous Peoples’ has an all-embracing and holistic perspective that encompasses everything, with no hierarchy in Creation. Their vision of a good life (“buen vivir”) is not exclusively religious and spiritual as our churches and religious teachers sometimes make us believe; nor is it economy-centred as our governments, the markets and the high street make us believe. Living out their spiritual and religious lives encompasses social, economic and political relationships with sisters and brothers, with living and non-living things, and with the Earth as a whole (“Pacha Mama”). They believe that the core is not human beings but Creation with its own integrity – and that human beings form part of Creation, which is continually searching for harmony and balance¹⁷. Some insights could also be drawn from Buddhism and other religions which emphasise a close relationship between humans and the rest of nature.

The fourth requirement for theological education in Africa is for Christians and Churches to advocate for the recognition of ecological debt that is owed to Africa and other countries of the global south; as well as to Indigenous peoples and the poor in the global north, as a step towards achieving eco-justice.¹⁸ This calls on African churches and governments to challenge international institutions and the United Nations and its institutions to flesh out international and national regulatory and legal frameworks that oblige ecological debtors (whether a country, corporation or institution) to stop destroying sources of sustenance, to repair, and to pay for ecological damages. This also calls on the churches to confront corporations and institutions that are wreaking havoc on our increasingly fragile ecosystems. Churches in India, Tanzania and the Philippines in partnership with churches in the North have been in the forefront of campaigns to halt destructive mining activities that have poisoned rivers and lands, and destroyed the livelihoods of tens of thousands of fisher folk and farmers. (Indeed some Christians in these countries have lost their lives in

Forum on Life Giving Agriculture, 25-30 August 2006, Seoul & Hongsung, Korea. Churches are very active in these areas to promote life giving agriculture.

¹⁵ Read about Cargil in Brewster Kneen, *Invisible Giant: Cargil and Its Transnational Strategies* (2nd ed; London: Pluto Press, 2002).

¹⁶ See the work being done by the WCC to develop the Greed line and Wealth line as guidance for Christians in Rogate Mshana, *Wealth Poverty and Ecology and their links*, WCC Publications, Geneva 2008, www.oikoumene.org

¹⁷ “Ecumenical Perspectives from Latin America and the Caribbean on Poverty Wealth and Ecology”, Indigenous Peoples Statement, WCC, Geneva 2009, 11.

¹⁸ See the WCC work on Ecological Debt in Athena Peralta (ed) *Ecological Debt: The Peoples of the South are Creditors: cases from Ecuador, Mozambique, Brazil and India* (Justice, Peace and Creation WCC Publications, 2005). See also the WCC Statement on Eco-justice and Ecological Debt, <http://www.oikoumene.org/resources/documents/central-committee/geneva-2009/reports-and-documents/report-on-public-issues/statement-on-eco-justice-and-ecological-debt.html>.

the fight against transnational mining companies.) Many churches, too, are advocating for the recognition of climate debt at the UN Forum for Climate Change, with a view to reaching a binding international agreement that ensures significant cuts in greenhouse gas emissions by rich, industrialized countries and urgent assistance to poor countries that need to mitigate and adapt to climate change.

The above four requirements for theological education are not exclusive of each other, they are interrelated concerns outlined as a way to lay bare the crucial components of what a redefined theological education curriculum would be like. That is what will lead to economic and social justice and an ecological mission that “greens” our faith, our churches and our congregations and offers Christians in Africa a model of authentic discipleship for today.

Need for an Alternative, Theological and Secular Education in Africa

In general the current dominant world view in education prepares young people to be objects of a system of over-consumption. The paradigm inculcates among people values of competition for resources instead of cooperation. They are taught that poverty will never be eradicated and that inequalities in society are a natural phenomenon and can never be overcome. They are educated to dominate nature instead of nurturing and living in harmony with it. Values of competition, selfishness, apathy and greed are promoted in colleges and schools. Ecology is taken for granted by corporations, which ‘externalise’ ecological damages to increase profits and employ ‘green-washing’ to enlarge their markets. Influenced by corporate lobbies, mainstream policymakers see the “green economy”, which continues to privilege economic growth, as the hope for the future. Corporate thinking is manifested and continuously reproduced in schools through business, economics and other curricula. The current knowledge that devalues creation has contributed to the intertwined economic, social and ecological crises confronting our planet today, which reflect an unjust and unsustainable mode of life on Earth. Africa has suffered a lot from this paradigm. We need bold steps not only for alternative theological education but also secular education that will produce new African intellectuals who think and act for autochthonous development in Africa directed to eradicate poverty, promote justice, peace and dignity as per the theme of the AACC Assembly 2013 in Kampala.

In summary, we need a theological education in Africa which will enable students and researchers to adequately address the root cause of poverty and injustice in Africa. In doing so, issues of economy and ecology need to be studied, with a view to understand the alternative God’s Oikos which guarantees abundant life for all. The book of James chapter 5 indicates that accumulation of wealth is considered an act of injustice over against those who have provided their labour so as to generate gains for a minority. In order to address this situation of injustice in social and economic transactions, the biblical tradition has provided different examples and ways to lead to redistribution – from the understanding of the Sabbath and the jubilee year to Paul’s collection for the community of Jerusalem. The announcement of the coming reign of God through Jesus as good news to the poor is linked with the expectation of the great reversal.¹⁹

Theological education for transformation in Africa ought to cover the following topics:

1. ECO-THEOLOGY AND SPIRITUALITY

- Revisiting God’s Creation
- Eco-reading of the Bible (green bible)
- Eco-spiritualities
- The Ubuntu view of creation
- Other alternative views of creation
- Eco-feminist theology and its view of creation

¹⁹ Konrad Raiser, “Theological and Ethical Considerations Regarding Wealth and the Call for Establishing a Greed line”, *The Ecumenical Review on Greed and Global Economics* WCC, 63:3 (2011), 279.

- Eco-spiritual praxis

2. GOD'S ECONOMY

- Understanding ecological economics
- Economy of sufficiency vs. economy of greed
- From competition to cooperation
- Revisiting scarcity theory
- De-commodification against monetizing the invaluable
- New eco-economic values
- Eco-economic measurements and indices (e.g. gross national happiness)
- Managing/caring for the "global ecological commons"
- Economy of care
- Fair trade and sustainable lifestyles
- Just finance – investing in just, participatory and sustainable communities
- Poverty eradication

3. SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY, SOCIETY AND ECOLOGY (STSE)

- Is science and technology always neutral and objective? – A critique of the 'scientific method'
- Science, technology and creation
- The Earth and people (i.e. the "inhabited ecosystem") – Social divisions and ecological framings and impacts
- Science of the "ecological commons" – water, land, air and fire

4. CRITICAL POLITICAL ECOLOGY

- Eco-global governance
- Towards an environmental criminal court
- Ecological debt and holistic reparations
- Eco-activism: social movements and ecological protection

Theological education that will embrace these subjects will enable students to adequately address the issue of poverty and justice in Africa.

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